Unit 9. Keeping the gospel central (Reflection)

Overview

This unit flows out of the study of 2 Timothy 2:1-7 and explores ways in which commitment to the gospel shapes the ministry of local church leaders. In doing so it teaches us how to "reflect" on the Scriptures and the situations we face and develops the BUILD 'ERA' model of theological reflection that is used throughout the BUILD curriculum.

Outline

- Introducing theological reflection
- The three steps of theological reflection
- Principles for gospel centred ministry
- 'ERA': A further look at the steps of theological reflection
- The BUILD logic of gospel ministry

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Recall and arrange the steps of theological reflection
2. Apply the steps of theological reflection to issues you encounter
3. Plan steps to make the gospel more central to your ministry
4. Use the acronym 'BUILD' to present the logic of gospel ministry

9.1 INTRODUCING THEOLOGICAL REFLECTION

9.1.1 What challenges are you facing?

We have seen that Timothy faced some very real challenges. Some individuals were distorting the gospel and destroying the church. We too face many struggles and difficulties in our own ministries.

- Individually or in a group: Identify a challenge or problem you are facing. If you are in a group write these down and then underline one or two that will benefit from further discussion later on in the unit. (NOTE: It might be a situation in your life or the life of your church that is puzzling. Or it might be a Scripture that is challenging.)

9.1.2 Going further and deeper

All too often our responses to the different experiences we face and the studies in the Bible we do are quickly forgotten and rarely lead to real change. Why is this the case and how can we go further and deeper? Discuss this together.

- Why do you think that so much teaching and learning fails to bring about any real change in people's lives? Where do you think the problem lies?

- How can we make sure that our encounters with the situations we face and the Scriptures God has given us lead to real learning and action?

9.1.3 "Reflect"

In the passage we have just encountered (2 Tim 2:1-7), Paul tells Timothy to pass on the gospel as a servant of Christ in the strength of Christ. Paul uses three pictures to illustrate what that means in practice and makes it clear to Timothy that he must do more than just read his words.

Paul knew that **reflection** was essential for real learning to take place and for action to happen. And so he ends that passage with a command that comes with a wonderful promise (2 Tim 2:7): "Reflect on what I am saying, for the Lord will give you insight into all this."

- Memorise that verse now and consider the importance of careful reflection and the Lord's kindness in opening the eyes of our hearts to his truths.

9.2 THE THREE STEPS OF THEOLOGICAL REFLECTION

How can we reflect more deeply and effectively on God's word and God's world? We will explore that question by looking more closely at Paul's words in 2 Tim 2:7 and by exploring one of the issues that you identified at the beginning of the unit.

As we do so we will discover that theological reflection is a three step process that encourages learning and action:

1. It begins when we **encounter** something in God's world and/or God's word with a desire for wisdom.

2. It continues with **reflection** on those situations and Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.

3. It leads to **action** in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.

9.2.1 Encounter

The first step is:

To encounter something in God's world and God's word with a desire for wisdom.

Paul tells Timothy to reflect "on" something. Theological reflection is an encounter with Scripture or experience. Scripture takes priority when it comes to shaping belief and behaviour, but we always encounter God's word in the context of the world around us.

Timothy is called to reflect on God's word in the midst of the situation he was facing. We too are to reflect on God's word in the context of all that is going on in our lives and churches and communities. Sometimes the issue or challenge is something we meet in the midst of our ministry. Sometimes it is something we meet in the Bible.

In the discipline of encounter you first **describe** things and you then **discover** things. That work of description and discovery involves asking and answering questions:

1. How did events unfold? Tell the story of what you experienced.
2. Who was involved in the experience? Describe the people.
3. What were the various people doing and saying? Record what happened.
4. Where and when did the events take place? Describe the situation.
5. What key things have you discovered that will need further reflection? List the different issues that have come to your attention.

- Apply the questions above to one of the challenges or issues you noted as a group at the beginning.

Summary points for the <u>encounter</u> step of theological reflection:

- To <u>encounter</u> something is to meet something new, surprising and unsettling.
- You need to <u>describe</u> the things you encounter and your reactions.
- You must list the <u>discoveries</u> you have made.

Your initial description and the discoveries you make will only be shallow. They will not explain the fuller meaning and significance of the encounter or experience. You must resist jumping to conclusions. Rather than taking action immediately you need to pause and go deeper by taking the next step.

9.2.2 Reflection

The second step is:

Reflection on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.

In 2 Timothy 2:7 Paul commands Timothy to "reflect" on what he has said about gospel ministry. Remember that any "insight" is a gift from "the Lord". Reflection is an opportunity for God to break into our lives, which means we need to make space for God's grace through prayer in the process. Do not rely on your own understanding.

In his reflection Timothy must consider three word pictures Paul has used: the images of soldier, athlete and farmer. It often helps if there is a *visual* aspect to our reflection, which helps us to think in fresh ways. (Diagrams, drawings and maps can help the process.)

But the most important thing is to *keep the gospel at the centre of your theological reflection*, to consider the situation in the light of God's good news. In verse 7 Timothy is called to "reflect" on God's word through Paul and in verse 8 to "remember" Jesus Christ, the heart of Paul's "gospel".

In the discipline of reflection you **consider** your discoveries and develop **principles**. Considering and developing principles means asking and answering questions:

1. Why might these things be happening? Note the reasons that might lie behind the description and discoveries. Give explanations.
2. What light does the gospel, the good news of God's grace, shed on all this? Keep the gospel at the heart of your reflection.
3. What Bible passages and themes are particularly relevant to the problem? List a few Scriptures that you think are important.
4. What pictures come to mind that help you to understand God's perspective on it? Explain any illustrations or draw any diagrams that help you to understand what is going on.
5. What principles seem to come from this process? List these lessons.

- Apply these questions to the discoveries you have made about the challenge or issue you noted as a group.

Summary points for the <u>reflection</u> step of theological reflection:

- To <u>reflect</u> is to pause for thought rather than to react. It is to question, to think and go deeper, to chew things over.
- You need to <u>consider</u> the discoveries you have made in the light of the God's word and in his presence.
- You must list the <u>principles</u>, the new perspectives or ways of looking at life and ministry that come from this.

It is tempting to leave these principles as interesting topics for discussion, as many academics do. But rather than leaving them as theories on a page, you need to put what you have learnt into practice and take the final step and prepare to take action.

9.2.3 Action

The final step is:

Action in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.

Paul calls Timothy to reflect on his words, which are God's words, for a purpose: so that he can be strengthened for a demanding ministry. Action is therefore not just about what you do but is also about why you do it, it is to be guided by the gospel.

Action means **planning** new approaches to ministry, testing things out and developing new **practice**.

We need to test our reflection by making a plan and taking action. We need to ask and answer questions such as:

1. How might all this change my attitudes?
2. What action can I take that will put these principles into practice?
3. What plans can I make in order to achieve this? (Make plans, whether formally or informally.)

- Apply these questions to the principles you have drawn out of your reflection on the challenge or issue you noted as a group. Note some of your plans below.

Summary points for the action step of theological reflection:

- To take action is to do something new or in a new way.
- You need to plan to put the principles into practice.
- The outcome will be new practice: ministry and mission that is more faithful to the gospel.

9.2.4 Summary table for the three steps of theological reflection

Step and description	Definition	Activity	Outcome
Encounter something in God's world and God's word with a desire for wisdom.	To meet something new and surprising	Describe	Discoveries
Reflection on those situations and the Scriptures in order to gain wisdom.	Pause for thought and go deeper	Consider	Principles
Action in God's world with the wisdom that comes from God's word.	Do something new or different	Plan	Practice

- Make sure you have understood the summary table ask and clarify any questions here.

9.3 PRINCIPLES FOR KEEPING THE GOSPEL CENTRAL

We have looked at some issues we are facing today in the light of the gospel, and we have been challenged to keep the gospel central in our life and ministry.

One way of listing, considering and remembering some of the principles we have noted is to use the letters that make up the word gospel – G O S P E L.

See if you can think of words that fit with the principles you have discovered and the plans you have made which begin with the letters G and O and S and P and E and L.

For example, the letter G might stand for 'God', because keeping the gospel central means honouring him. His will and his ways matter more than anything else.

You might think of more than one word for each letter. Pick the best two and use them in the table below. Your Trainer can help you with this.

Principles for keeping the gospel central to our life and ministry:

God – keeping the gospel central means honouring God. His will and his ways matter more than anything else.	**G**
O	**O**
S	**S**
P	**P**
E	**E**
L	**L**

9.4 'ERA': A FURTHER LOOK AT THE STEPS OF THEOLOGICAL REFLECTION

9.4.1 The word 'ERA' is a simple way to remember the steps

In English the word **'ERA'** is a simple and helpful way of remembering these three steps:

> **E** is for **Encounter**, **R** is for **Reflection**, **A** is for **Action**.

And this way of remembering the steps has real meaning. The word 'era' means a significant period of history. For example, the reign of a king is known as the era of that ruler.

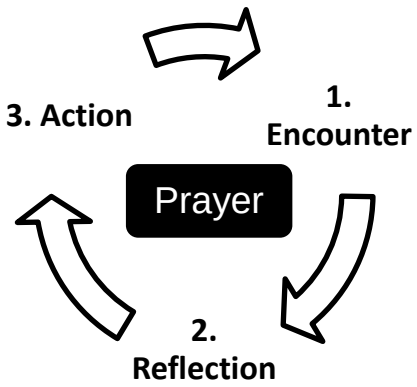
That is why ERA is a helpful way of remembering this cycle: the reason we wrestle with the situations we face in the light of the gospel, and the reason we then return to the often difficult context of God's world in order to take action in a renewed way is to bring about change and transformation.

The change we are seeking is that God's "will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (Matt 6:10). In other words, the aim of our reflection is to point to God's Kingdom, the new era God is bringing in and through his king Jesus.

9.4.2 The steps of theological reflection as a cycle

Having encountered God's world and God's word we reflect and then act. But as we take action in God's world with the wisdom of God's word we will make fresh discoveries and have new experiences. Those new encounters will deepen our reflection and refine our action.

This means that the three steps of encounter, reflection and action can be understood as steps in a cycle. That cycle is illustrated below.



Prayer lies at the heart of the process because that desire for wisdom must be continuous throughout:

> "If any of you lacks wisdom, you should ask God, who gives generously to all without finding fault, and it will be given to you." (James 1:5)

9.5 EXTRA: THE BUILD LOGIC OF GOSPEL MINISTRY

To close this unit we will link this learning to the word 'BUILD'. In Unit 1 we learnt the meaning of the acronym 'BUILD':

B	is for	**Biblical** …	2 Tim 3:16-17
U	is for	**Understanding** …	2 Tim 2:15
I	is for	**In-service** …	2 Tim 1:8
L	is for	**Leadership** …	2 Tim 2:2
D	is for	**Development** …	2 Tim 3:14

Here we will build on this by seeing that the order in which the letters B – U – I – L – D come can be used to teach an important logic to gospel ministry, a pattern that we have been discovering in this unit.

9.5.1 The order of the letters B – U – I – L – D and the words they represent

First, the order of the letters BUILD and the words they stand for is important. Consider the order they are in below:

1. Biblical
The Bible and its gospel are of immense value
"Scripture..." (2 Tim 3:16-17)

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2. Understanding
We must use it all with great care
"Handles..." (2 Tim 2:15)

🡻

3. In-service
That includes using it in practice in mission
"Reflect..." (2 Tim 2:7)

🡻

4. Leadership
And in passing on true gospel ministry to others
"Entrust..." (2 Tim 2:2)

🡻

5. Development
This is an ongoing commitment
"Continue..." (2 Tim 3:14)

Think about the importance of that order and progression:

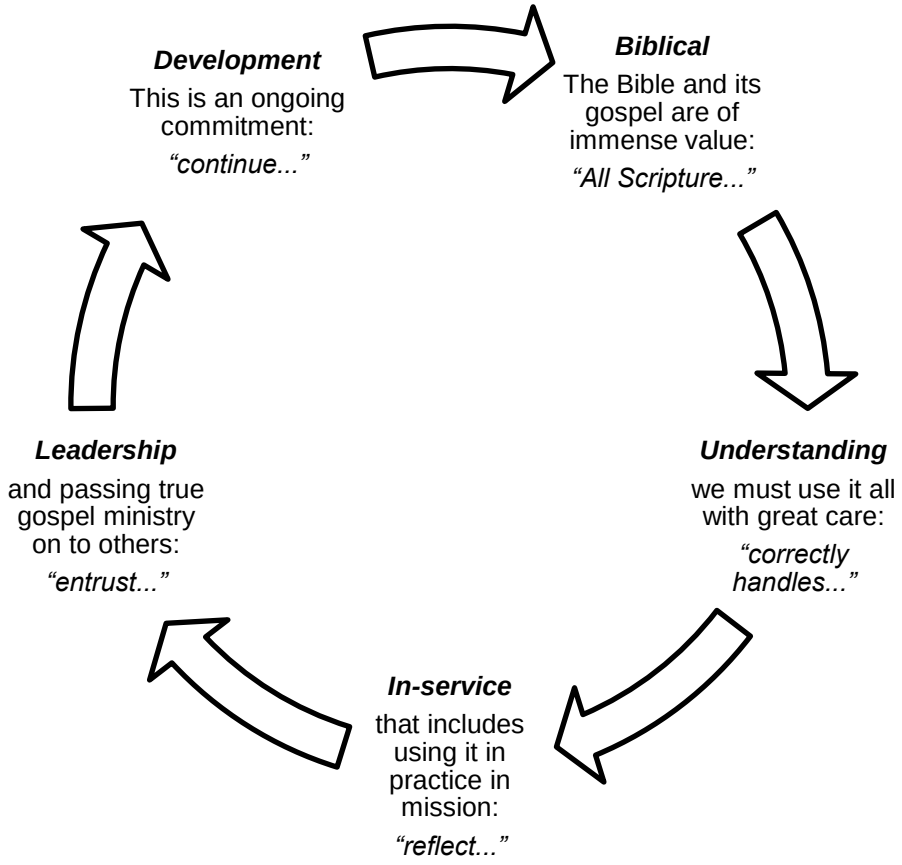
> First, the Bible is a great treasure that bears God's authority.
>
> So, second, we must handle it and the glorious gospel it contains, the word of truth, with great care.
>
> Third, following on from that, careful use of Scripture and truth is not simply about preserving the gospel, it is about sharing it and being strengthened by it. The Bible and the word of life it contains are God's gift for a church on a mission.
>
> And, fourth, part of that mission is to pass it on to others: to train trustworthy and true ministers of the gospel.
>
> Fifth and finally, all this is an ongoing process that involves every dimension of our lives: all true teachers of the gospel must continue in what they have learnt and have become convinced of, watching both life and doctrine.

9.5.2 The BUILD learning cycle

This order can also be understood as a cycle. If you are going to grow as a leader you must "continue in what you have learnt" (2 Tim 3:14). Therefore it is important to see that the letters 'BUILD' form a cycle of growth and learning. Persevering in the ongoing process of true gospel ministry means the following. We must:

1. Constantly return to Scripture (Biblical)
2. Renew our grasp of the gospel (Understanding)
3. Use the gospel more and more in practice (In-service)
4. Develop ourselves as leaders as we develop others (Leadership)
5. Continue with this, encouraged by the joys and despite the disappointments (Development)

This is illustrated below:



- Read through the cycle and make sure you understand the logic of the steps. Try and explain them to another participant in order to test out and improve your understanding.

- End by explaining to the others in your group which step you find the most challenging, and pray about some of the issues that raises.